Blanquerna–Ramon Llull University, School of Communication and International Relations Official Master's degree in Advanced Studies in International Affairs

Subject: 75881 Geopolitics of the Contemporary World and Global Governance

Name of the course: Latin America and the Caribbean

Title of the paper : Who Governs Latin America? Fragmented Authority and the Politics of Power in the 21st Century continent

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Date of presentation : Sunday March 29th

Wordcount : 2507 words

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Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) have undergone significant transformations since the late 20th century, transitioning from authoritarian regimes to formally democratic systems. Even with these advances, the area is now dealing with significant issues, such as political division, weak institutions, and a drop in public confidence in democratic systems. The V-Dem Institute (2025) notes that many nations in the region are going through autocratization, which means the slow decay of democratic values and structures. This pattern represents what Steven Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt (2018) refer to as democratic erosion, a situation where chosen officials weaken democracy internally instead of through sudden shifts to authoritarian rule. At the same time, structural inequalities are a continuous pattern of the geopolitical area. Latin America continues to be one of the most unequal areas globally, with differences in wealth, land, and access to public services playing a major role in how governance and representation function (Díez Pinto *et al.,*2025). Within this framework, political authority should not be viewed only through official state bodies. Rather, it is increasingly shaped by the interactions among various participants working at multiple levels. This change shows a wider variety of political players in LAC.. Even though governments and presidents are still important for political power, other groups—like political parties, social movements, wealthy individuals, and global organizations—are becoming more important in affecting governance and decision-making. This leads to an important question: who are the key political players influencing power in Latin America and the Caribbean today, and in what ways do they impact governance and decision-making in the area?

Our essay will argue that, although national governments remain the main political actor in the region, in the long geopolitical tradition of the continent, political power in LAC is more and more shaped by the relationships among political figures, divided party systems, social groups, social movements, and global organizations. While this variety of participants can improve political involvement and representation, it also leads to division, conflicts within institutions, and difficulties for democratic rule. The analysis will examine each actor's role and its impact on governance and policy-making.

I. The State : Governments and President keep the central geopolitical role in the region

Governments and heads of state play a key role in the formal politics of LAC because of the strong presence of presidential systems in the area. Aside from their official duties, presidents have a major impact on governance and policymaking as they can create national agendas, lead political discussions, and affect the power dynamics among government branches. This importance arises not only from how their systems are designed but also from historical leadership trends, especially the tradition of caudillismo, where power is held by influential, charismatic leaders who represent political legitimacy and national vision.

From a theoretical standpoint, the concentration of power within the executive has been examined extensively in studies. Juan J. Linz (1990) claims that presidential systems often create institutional conflicts because both the executive and legislative branches have their own legitimacy, which can cause disputes or gridlock. Scott Mainwaring and Matthew Shugart (1997) delve deeper into this idea, revealing that in Latin America, presidencies often feature powerful leaders working within divided party politics. In this setting, the concept of hyperpresidentialism describes how presidents tend to hold concentrated

decision-making power, allowing them to extend their reach into lawmaking, administration, and public messaging. This actor plays a central role in Latin American history, but also today.

Javier Milei in Argentina has showcased a very centralized and populist style of leadership, using his presidential power to drive major economic changes and influence political conversations. Similarly, in Mexico, Andrés Manuel López Obrador (AMLO) has amassed power in the executive branch, strongly shaping the legislative agenda and public discussions. Jair Bolsonaro's presidency in Brazil demonstrated the discord that may occur between the executive and other parts of government, notably the judiciary, revealing the difficulties of keeping a balanced system with a strong presidential presence. These cases illustrate that presidents serve not just as administrative figures but also as crucial actors in defining political direction and institutional behavior. They set the political agenda and are in the center of the political and geopolitical actors.

Nonetheless, the extent of presidential power is not boundless and must be viewed within a framework of limitations. Legislative opposition, judicial oversight, and constitutional safeguards can greatly limit how executives carry out their plans. Moreover, external influences from global organizations and financial entities may constrain policy flexibility, especially in matters concerning economic adjustments and fiscal strategies. Linz (1990) points out that the inherent characteristics of presidential systems, combined with politically fragmented landscapes, can result in governance difficulties, such as political standstills or executive overreach.

In summary, presidential influence in LAC acts as a major force in governance while also posing potential risks for democracy. Although presidents have considerable power to mold policy and political discussion, their influence is constantly subject to negotiation and limitations imposed by institutional, political, and international elements. This complexity underscores the nature of political authority in the region, where dominant executive leadership exists alongside structural limitations and diverse sources of influence. In reality, the influence of the presidents is greatly influenced by how political parties are organized and operate, which affects both elections and legislative backing. Yet, in numerous Latin American nations, the party systems often show division, lack stability, and unpredictability, which can limit or strengthen the president's authority.Thus, understanding presidential power requires examining party systems, as they structure representation and coalition-building (Dagnino, 2008).

II. Political Parties : Structuring Competition and Representation

As Mainwaring and Shugart (1997) argue, presidential systems in LAC are deeply shaped by the interaction between executives and party systems. Mainwaring (2018) emphasizes that many party systems in the region remain weakly institutionalized, lacking stable voter alignments and organizational strength. Levitsky and Roberts (2011) highlight the resurgence and transformation of party competition in the region, particularly with the emergence of new leftist movements and political realignments. Similarly, Roberts (2014) emphasizes processes of party system collapse and reconfiguration, which have led to the rise of new political actors and shifting electoral coalitions.

This lack of stability results in constant changes to party structures, the rise of new political groups, and challenges in maintaining consistent policy initiatives. Consequently, instead of providing stability to the political framework, some parties contribute to uncertainty and separation. This separation has significant consequences for governance, especially in presidential systems. Party systems that are weak or fragmented often hinder presidents from achieving stable legislative majorities, which can either restrict their ability to carry out policies or, on the other hand, enhance presidential authority through other means like decrees or informal discussions. In this way, the weakness of parties might inexplicably boost presidential power while diminishing the efficiency of legislative discussions and institutional fairness. Examples from the region highlight these patterns.

In Peru, a highly fragmented party system features weak institutional parties and regular shifts among politicians, leading to unstable governance and challenges in achieving coherent policy-making. In Chile, the classic party system has experienced notable changes after the 2019 social protests, reshaping political alignments and giving rise to new political entities. Likewise, in Colombia, the emergence of fresh movements and coalitions has modified the traditional party environment, indicating wider political realignment trends. These situations reveal how instability in party systems can transform both representation and governance results. Nonetheless, despite these issues, political parties are vital for a functioning democracy. Even in fragmented systems, they still organize electoral competition, offer avenues for political engagement, and facilitate the expression of societal interests through institutional paths. Additionally, changes in the party system can symbolize democratic renewal, with new players and movements entering the political scene and broadening representation. Thus, although weak institutionalization may lead to instability, it can also create opportunities for political diversity and evolution. In summary, political parties in Latin America and the Caribbean hold a crucial role: they are essential for democratic representation and governance, but their fragmentation and weak institutionalization frequently hinder their efficiency. This situation closely interacts with presidentialism, affecting the distribution of power between executives and legislatures and impacting the overall quality and stability of governance in the region. Therefore, party system fragmentation does not simply weaken governance; it restructures it by shifting power toward the executive, often at the expense of institutional balance.

III. Social Movements and Civil Society

In present-day Latin America and the Caribbean, engaging in politics is increasingly seen outside of traditional institutions, as groups come together to voice their needs and impact public policymaking. Beyond established political entities such as governments and political parties, social movements and organizations within civil society have taken on a more influential role in the region. These groups are vital in voicing social needs, rallying citizens, and holding governments responsible, especially when official representation seems weak or unresponsive. Instead of working strictly within formal decision-making bodies, social movements tend to affect governance through protests, public pressure, and shaping the agenda from outside the established political framework.

The significance of social movements in this region has been thoroughly examined in academic work. Sidney Tarrow (2011) describes social movements as types of contentious politics that arise when groups unite to oppose authorities or seek change. In LAC, this situation is particularly relevant due to the region's history of inequality, social exclusion, and political sidelining. Likewise, Evelina Dagnino (2008) highlights how civil society plays a crucial role in enhancing participatory democracy, showing how group efforts can either support or challenge formal institutions to be more inclusive and responsive. In reality, social movements in LAC have significantly influenced discussions on policy and institutional changes. For instance, the protests in Chile in 2019 involved many people calling for increased social equality and triggered a constitutional reform process. Feminist groups like Ni Una Menos have raised awareness about gender violence and affected policies regarding gender equality in numerous countries. Indigenous activists in places like Bolivia, Ecuador, and Peru have also been pivotal in advocating for land rights, environmental safeguards, and cultural acknowledgment. Such examples demonstrate how social movements can broaden political participation and bring new topics to the forefront of public discussions.

From a governance viewpoint, social movements aid in democratization by encouraging citizen involvement and enhancing accountability. They often serve as bridges between underrepresented groups and political organizations, ensuring that those who are sidelined from conventional party systems still have a voice in political conversations. In this way, they can mitigate the shortcomings of disjointed party systems and limited institutional representation by providing alternative paths for participation. However, the power of social movements also brings certain difficulties for governance. Major mobilizations can lead to political instability, especially when the demands are wide-ranging, scattered, or hard to turn into clear policies. Sometimes, persistent protests can undermine institutional authority or create demands for quick reforms that governments cannot handle. Additionally, the informal nature of many movements can pose challenges in reaching lasting agreements with state institutions.

In summary, social movements and civil society groups are a lively and increasingly vital element of political power in LAC. They act both as promoters of democratization and as sources of pressure on political systems, influencing governance through shaping public discussions, uniting actions, and holding leaders accountable. Their growing influence showcases the broader variety of political players in the region, reinforcing the idea that governance arises from the interaction between formal bodies and societal forces, not just from state actors alone.

IV. Economic Elites and Business Groups: Structural influence on policy-making

In one of the most unequal regions in the world, economic power remains a key determinant of political influence and policy outcomes. In this sense, economic elites and business groups, represents a key factor, yet, less visible, of political influence and policy outcomes. From a Dependency Theory perspective, Latin American economies have historically developed within a dependent relationship to core capitalist countries, limiting autonomous development and reinforcing unequal exchange patterns (Prebisch, 1950; Cardoso and Faletto, 1979) From this perspective, international financial institutions and global economic actors are not neutral, but actively shape domestic policy choices, often constraining state sovereignty through debt, conditionality, and trade structures.

Unlike those in elected positions or social movements, their impact is mainly felt not through political representation but via their management of financial resources, investment abilities, and access to key decision-makers. Consequently, they have a fundamental role in influencing public policy, especially in areas like taxation, labor laws, and economic changes.

Research indicates that economic elites maintain a lasting influence in LAC. Ben Ross Schneider (2013) refers to the economies in Latin America as types of hierarchical capitalism, where major business groups have close links with political leaders and have substantial power over policy decisions. In the same way, Jeffrey A. Winters (2011) defines oligarchy as a situation where wealthy individuals utilize their assets to protect and promote their interests, frequently impacting political results in their favor. These viewpoints imply that economic elites are not just players in the economy but also important figures in the political landscape. It's determinant in the case of LAC geopoliticals outcomes. Business groups sway governance through various methods. They take part in lobbying, fund political campaigns, and help shape negotiations around policies that directly relate to their interests. For example, in numerous Latin American nations, these economic elites have been crucial in molding tax reforms, often opposing progressive taxation or promoting regulations that favor businesses. During the government of Michelle Bachelet (2014–2018), major business groups and economic elites actively mobilized against proposed tax reforms aimed at increasing redistribution. They used the media influences and lobby to obtain gains. As Fairfield (2015) demonstrates, business influence has significantly shaped tax policy in the region, often limiting redistributive reforms.From a governance viewpoint, the sway of economic elites can lead to both stabilizing and challenging outcomes. Their participation can boost economic steadiness, investment, and consistent policies, all vital for progress. However, their excessive power raises issues regarding democratic fairness and state integrity, especially when policy choices reflect the needs of a limited group rather than the wider public. In situations of significant inequality, this pattern can reinforce the current social divides and weaken the legitimacy of democratic systems.

Additionally, the ties between political leaders and economic elites can blur lines between public and private interests. Sometimes, strong connections between government and business entities have resulted in accusations of favoritism, corruption, or clientelism, making governance even more complex. This interaction underscores how economic strength can lead to political sway, influencing not only specific policies but also larger patterns of development. While their involvement can support economic stability and policy knowledge, it also prompts critical questions about democratic representation and fairness, highlighting the uneven and contested nature of political power in the region.

V. IO's and External Actors.

In a world that is becoming more connected, the political authority in LAC is influenced not only by local players but also by foreign global organizations and outside countries. International entities and foreign influences are key in shaping how the region is governed and how policies are made by providing financial help, offering policy advice, and spreading institutional standards. Their impact is often indirect, differing from local actors, yet it can significantly affect national policy choices, mainly in economic management, development plans, and democratic practices. Important organizations such as the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank, the Organization of American States, and the

Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development play a key role in governance (IMF, 2025; World Bank, 2025; OAS, 2025; OECD, 2025). These institutions supply funding, expert advice, and frameworks that guide local governance. For instance, international financial institutions often affect economic and fiscal strategies by placing conditions on loans, which compel governments to adopt certain reforms to obtain financial backing. This situation has been especially clear during times of economic crises when nations rely on outside funding to stabilize their finances.

In addition to financial aid, international organizations also promote governance standards such as transparency, accountability, and democratic principles. The OAS has played a key role in promoting democratic governance and monitoring elections across the region (OAS, 2025), while the OECD supports policy coordination and institutional reforms (OECD, 2025).

Likewise, the OECD advocates for policy coordination and reforms aimed at enhancing economic effectiveness and public management. These influences demonstrate how governance in LAC is intertwined with a larger system of global standards and institutional structures.

Moreover, beyond these multilateral organizations, external powers like the United States, China, and the European Union also affect the political and economic situation in the region. Their influence manifests through trade relationships, investment opportunities, and diplomatic ties. For instance, changing global dynamics—such as the international consequences of the conflict in Ukraine—have impacted how Latin American countries position themselves in global politics, affecting their economic relationships and foreign policy decisions. This shows that governance in the region transcends being purely national and is also shaped by international power dynamics.

From a governance standpoint, the involvement of international influences brings both advantages and limitations. On one hand, external support can foster economic stability, strengthen institutions, and enhance policy knowledge. Conversely, it can also restrict national independence, especially when policy choices are swayed by outside conditions or geopolitical pressures. The tension between outside influence and local self-governance is a significant aspect of the regional governance landscape. This situation is especially evident in the Caribbean, where small island nations tend to show greater economic vulnerability and reliance on external aid. Regional organizations like the Caribbean Community (CARICOM) play a crucial role in policy coordination and representation of shared interests, while international financial institutions are essential partners in development strategies. Consequently, governance in these nations is often influenced by a mix of national priorities and external pressures, highlighting the unequal power dynamics in the region. For instance, according to recent international financial data, Argentina's 2022 agreement with the IMF amounted to approximately $44 billion, making it one of the largest IMF programs in the world and illustrating the scale at which such institutions can influence national economic policy and reform agendas. (IMF, 2025)

In summary, international organizations and foreign actors form an essential aspect of political authority in LAC. Their influence goes beyond mere financial aid to include shaping policies, establishing institutional norms, and influencing geopolitical relations playing a key role in shaping the governance of the region. This underscores the notion that governance in

the region results from intricate interactions between local and international participants, where sovereignty is continually redefined in a globalized political and economic landscape.

This interaction fuels increasing political polarization, as illustrated by recent electoral dynamics. On one side, left-wing movements mobilize popular sectors around redistributive and anti-imperialist agendas, while on the other, far-right leaders capitalize on insecurity and economic concerns (Atlantic Council, 2025; ACLED, 2025).

CONCLUSION :

As a conclusion, political authority in LAC cannot be fully grasped by only considering the state's official role. Even though governments and presidents are the main players in the system, this essay has demonstrated that governance in this region is more and more shaped by various political forces, such as political parties, social groups, wealthy individuals, and global organizations. Each of these groups has a specific way of affecting policy development, which can include institutional power, competition in elections, community activism, financial influence, and external pressures. This mix of influences shows a change in the political systems within the region, where authority is not solely held within formal institutions but is dispersed across different areas. On one hand, this variety can improve democratic involvement, enhance representation, and bring new issues into the political arena. On the other hand, it can lead to division, conflicts within institutions, and difficulties in maintaining efficient governance, especially in places with fragile political party systems and significant inequality.

In this setting, political power in LAC should be seen as something that is constantly challenged and negotiated, rather than something that is centralized and steady. While presidents may have power in formal institutions, their ability to lead is influenced by their relationships with parties, social groups, economic stakeholders, and international limits. This intricate situation shows both the strength and the vulnerability of democratic governance in this region. In the end, the key challenge for democracies in LAC is finding a way to balance strong political leadership with stable institutions, social inclusion, and efficient policy-making. The way governance develops in the region will rely on how well these various players can work together within effective democratic systems, making sure that increased diversity does not compromise governability or democratic responsibility. The balance of power, as well as the institutional stability will be key indicators in the future. Understanding this plural configuration of political actors is essential for analyzing the future of democratic governance in the region.

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